and demand action.[12] But the ‘problem of inheritance’ that he refers to is not one of India alone, but also of Pakistan, if recent evidence is anything to go by.

Perhaps the person who has best encapsulated the significance of Bhagat Singh in today’s politics in the Indian subcontinent is the Oxford-based economist Professor Pritam Singh, who wrote a piece in 2007 for Bhagat Singh’s 100th birth anniversary. In it, he lamented how little was appreciated about Bhagat Singh even in his own native country despite the fact that `[a]s an icon, Bhagat Singh can be called the Che Guevara of India. Yet, his 100th birth anniversary was the least celebrated of all the anniversaries except the 250th anniversary of the Battle of Plassey’. This is because it ‘represents a challenge to almost every tendency in Indian politics’, given how the ‘Gandhi-inspired Indian nationalists, Hindu nationalists, Sikh nationalists, the parliamentary Left and the pro-armed struggle Naxalite Left compete with each other to appropriate the legacy of Bhagat Singh, and yet each one of them is faced with a contradiction in making a claim to his legacy’. Thus, as he explains,

> Gandhi-inspired Indian nationalists find Bhagat Singh’s resort to violence problematic, the Hindu and Sikh nationalists find his atheism troubling, the parliamentary Left finds his ideas and actions as more close to the perspective of the Naxalites and the Naxalites find Bhagat Singh’s critique of individual terrorism in his later life an uncomfortable historical fact.

Pritam Singh may just as well have added that across the border from India the people of Pakistan too struggle to lay claim to him as one of their own —not only was he not religious, but he was also not a Muslim. So, the enigma of Bhagat Singh is to do with who can claim him, and as a result what we have are `the claims of different contestations to the legacy of Bhagat Singh’.

In fact, given how Bhagat Singh’s developmental years were lived in what is today Pakistan, the claim on him is no less strong there. This is reflected in the words of Indian writers. Professor Chaman Lal, in his latest book *The Bhagat Singh Reader*, marvels at how it is that, ‘[l]ooking back,